

Making sense of algorithms: learning how to carry on in digital media landscapes

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Digital ethnography of TikTok consumption

Methods



Digital fieldwork on
TikTok app (0.5 year)



Interviews with
TikTok users



Media mapping
techniques



Participant observation
of scrolling behaviour

Fieldwork



1.5 years of
fieldwork in
2020/21

Working with group of
30 UK-based young
adults for 1 year



De-constructing mundane experiences of algorithms

"Entertainment is usually associated with simple, uncomplicated pleasure ... this is to evade the obligation to investigate which mechanisms lie at the basis of that pleasure" (Ang 1985: 19).



Trust issues continuously shaped experiences of TikTok

"I try not to be too surprised but sometimes, yeah, it is like content seems very driven towards you or a situation you are going through. But yeah, I guess less so now because I've used it more and, I mean, I've liked so many videos. Whoever is in control can see exactly what I'm into. It's less surprising ... **but still weird. I'm still feeling like there is a spy in my phone** because videos can get very specific" - (Rhea)



Trust is a key mediator of these relational dynamics



Trust tests

Embodied experiences forcing people to stop in their movement and reflect on what's ahead.

Mediators

Educational background and interest in data topics



Prior experience dealing with digital platforms



Multiple mechanisms

🧠 Strategic ignorance: although not always on their mind, questions of trustworthiness were always in (the back of) people's mind.

💬 Stories: the TikTok algorithm, and its transgressions of being too (un)specific were actively discussed with peers.

📱 Interne culture: people drew on memes (like "FBI agent watching you") and online discourses to make sense of surveillance.

Literacy + stories about algorithms

- Stories as a mechanism to create shared experience – after all, that's the material out which cultures are made.
- Stories as a way to counter commercial logics of personalisation and foreground communal modes of co-orientation.
- Stories as a means to nurture literacy: coping mechanisms, fostering understanding, opening angles for critique, space for reflection.

The role of hype in configuring power dynamics

- Configuring human-machine relations: power dynamics and abilities to be critical stance towards machines.
- Question how techno-hypes undermine literacy efforts: thinking about Eliza therapist and illusion of depth, projection of intelligence, and familiarity in language.
- Both ways: people are key in making things personalised – does it also mean and not all unease is just coming from the algorithm?

Welcome to

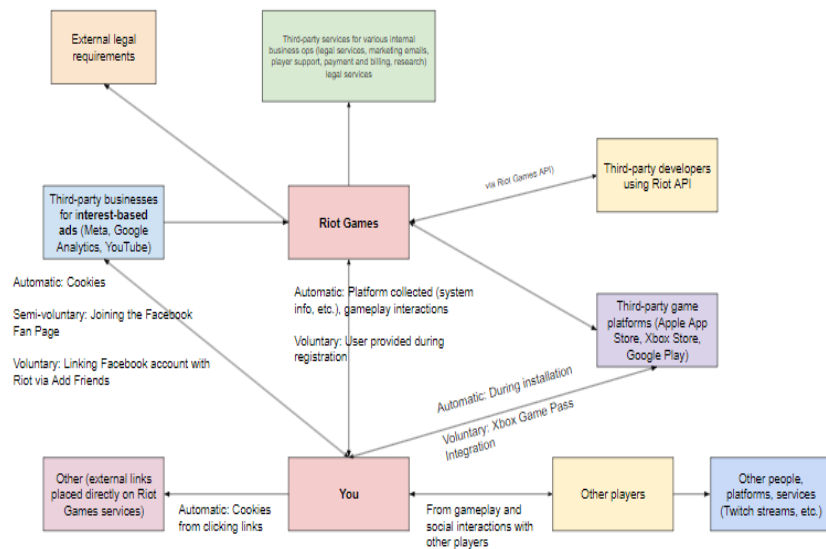
```
EEEEEE LL      IIII ZZZZZZ  AAAAA  
EE      LL      II       ZZ   AA   AA  
EEEEEE LL      II       ZZZ   AAAAAA  
EE      LL      II       ZZ   AA   AA  
EEEEEE LLLLLL  IIII ZZZZZZ  AA   AA
```

Eliza is a mock Rogerian psychotherapist.
The original program was described by Joseph Weizenbaum in 1966.
This implementation by Norbert Landsteiner 2005.

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ELIZA: Is something troubling you ?  
YOU:   Men are all alike.  
ELIZA: What is the connection, do you suppose ?  
YOU:   They're always bugging us about something or other.  
ELIZA: Can you think of a specific example ?  
YOU:   Well, my boyfriend made me come here.  
ELIZA: Is it important to you that your boyfriend made you come here ?  
YOU:   He says I'm depressed much of the time.  
ELIZA: I am sorry to hear that you are depressed.  
YOU:   It's true. I am unhappy.  
ELIZA: Can you explain what made you unhappy ?  
YOU:
```

Broadening the scope on platform algorithms

- 3 billion gamers + key leisure activity for youths and adults.
- Gaming is a form of social media practice, as well as adjacent data practices.
- Overlap in data usage personalisation (matchmaking) or moderation (anti-toxicity).
- Gaming also seamlessly integrates into the larger ad tech landscape.
- Apart from occasional controversies, most gamers seem largely accepting about algorithmic practices in that sphere of the digital landscape? Why and how?



Visualisation of data practices and relationships for the case of Riot Games (League of Legends)

Thanks!

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